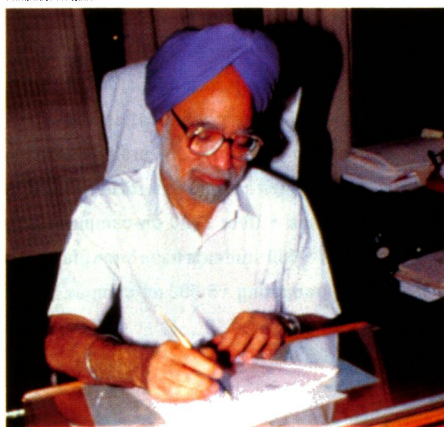


REMAINS OF THE DAY

Former prime minister and front-runner in the 1991 polls, Rajiv Gandhi was killed by an LTTE suicide bomber at an election rally in Sriperumbudur. Fired by a new optimism and unburdened of the IPKF debacle, Gandhi never saw it coming as the bespectacled Thenmuli Rajaratnam garlanded him and bent, ostensibly to touch his feet—except that she was bending only to detonate the bomb-belt she was wearing under her salwar kameez. A dream was over, and a nightmare had just begun. The LTTE's IPKF score had been settled. In blood.

PRASHANT PANJAB



“I HAVE THE PM’S MANDATE”

Manmohan Singh

So said Oxford-educated finance minister Manmohan Singh. He promised to think big and he did. In July, as loans burgeoned and the public sector lay defunct, it took this mild-mannered academic to give the economy the kind of shock therapy it needed. Doing away with industrial licencing, relaxing investment norms and devaluing the rupee to more realistic market levels—this was Singh's bitter pill for India's anaemic economy. When he pushed the most radical policy rethink ever, saying, “The world must know India has changed”, Singh, for once, won a unanimous, if begrudging, agreement.

FIRST CUT

• The world's first railroad hospital, the Jeevan Rekha (Lifeline Express), set off on July 16. The train, with coaches donated by the Indian Railways, was operated by the Impact India Foundation.

• P.V. Narasimha Rao liberalised India's protectionist economy in reaction to a severe foreign exchange crisis.

• President's rule lifted from Punjab after five years to make way for elections in 1992.

<< REWIND



<< DID YOU KNOW

Chandra Sekhar was India's shortest-serving prime minister, with the exception of A.B. Vajpayee's 13-day coalition of 1996. Holding office for seven months, Shekhar resigned on March 6, 1991 after the Congress withdrew support.